Usiri Marketplace — one-page executive summary

A proposed multi-vendor e-commerce and coordinated-delivery platform for Dar es Salaam

Status: Concept under investigation. Not an approved project. No Usiri partnership, franchise, licence, funding or integration exists. All figures are planning assumptions.

The idea

A curated marketplace where verified Tanzanian shops sell everyday home, kitchen and small electrical goods to Dar es Salaam households. The platform brings customers, collects payment through a licensed provider, coordinates delivery through a licensed carrier, handles returns and stands behind the order. It does not buy stock, own a warehouse or run a fleet at pilot stage. It earns an 8% commission (to be tested at 6–12%), a supplier subscription, a delivery coordination fee and, later, sponsored placement.

Why the group sees an opportunity

Mobile money is now mainstream: about 75.78 million active mobile money users and 2.79 million merchants in 2025 [S6]. Internet subscriptions reached 49.3 million by March 2025 [S5]. Yet much online buying still happens through Instagram, WhatsApp and classifieds, where the buyer pays a stranger and delivery is improvised. Jumia left Tanzania in 2019 and had not confirmed a return as of November 2025 [S9][S10]. No locally dominant operator currently combines verified sellers, reliable delivery and buyer protection at scale.

The honest numbers

At an assumed TZS 75,000 average order, each order contributes about **TZS 3,730** before fixed costs. A moderate structure loses about **TZS 770,000 a month at 1,000 orders**. The business only works at volume, with disciplined fixed costs and ancillary revenue.

Scenario	Monthly fixed costs	Break-even orders/month	Orders/day	12-month funding need
Lean	TZS 2.2m	295	10	TZS 31.2m
Moderate	TZS 5.6m	1,206	40	TZS 129.8m
Ambitious	TZS 12.0m	2,922	97	TZS 324.9m

The lean scenario is the only one a student group could plausibly fund from savings. It assumes unpaid founders and a minimal team. The moderate and ambitious scenarios require outside capital and a proven operating playbook.

The Usiri question

Usiri describes 6+ years, 50+ routes and 100+ agents in transport and parcel carriage [S1][S2]. These are self-reported claims. No API, rate card, liability terms or working tracking page could be found; the tracking link returned HTTP 404 [S4]. Usiri is therefore a **candidate partner for investigation**, not a foundation. A future deal could combine a preferred-carrier agreement, a narrow brand licence and collection-point access, each with separate written terms. The project can proceed under an independent brand with two carriers if Usiri declines.

Recommendation

Do not launch. Fund a bounded research phase: eight weeks, TZS 2–5 million, named owners, and a written go/no-go decision. The research must test whether customers will pay TZS 5,000–7,000 for delivery, whether 15+ suppliers will accept 8%, what carriers actually charge, and whether a brand licence is affordable and non-exclusive. No franchise fee or brand-specific investment should be paid before due diligence.

What the group must decide

1. Approve, revise, pause or stop the research phase.
2. Set the budget cap and appoint phase owners.
3. Agree the evidence thresholds and stop-loss triggers.
4. Agree founder roles, equity, IP and decision rights in writing.
5. Confirm that the project proceeds on an independent-brand track in parallel with any Usiri discussion.

Bottom line: this is a real problem and a hard business. The next step is not to build an app; it is to spend a small amount of money finding out whether customers, suppliers and carriers will actually support the model.

Sources are listed in Appendix B of the full concept document. This summary is not legal, tax or investment advice.